

Chama Management Platform - User Guide

How a savings group is run on the platform, role by role, with demo sign-ins for admin, chairperson and member.

Revision 1 - July 2026 | Abdikarim, Frontend Developer & Freelancer

Where to go

Platform

<https://chama-management-platform-hazel.vercel.app>

One address for everyone. What you can see and do is decided by the role on your account, not by a separate app.

Sign-in details

Admin

Email: abdkarimochieng@gmail.com
Password: Chama@Admin2026

Group setup, membership, roles and subscription billing.

Chairperson

Email: ochiengabdikarim@gmail.com
Password: @Abdik2109

Approves payouts and loan disbursements, sees full group position.

Member

Email: abdizovicabdi@gmail.com
Password: #Abdik2109

Contributes, and sees their own history plus the group totals.

Please read: These are shared demo accounts on a public deployment. Anyone reading this guide can sign in with them, so treat everything inside as throwaway sample data: do not enter real names, phone numbers, ID numbers or live payment details. Passwords are rotated from time to time - if one stops working, get in touch and I will send the current set. Sign in with all three accounts in turn - the point of the platform is how differently the same screens behave depending on who is looking at them.

1. What the platform is for

A chama runs on trust, and trust runs on a record everyone agrees with. In most groups that record is the treasurer's notebook plus a WhatsApp thread of M-Pesa screenshots. Contributions get missed, the running total is whatever the treasurer last said it was, and a member who wants to check their own history has to ask someone.

This platform replaces the notebook. Contributions come in over M-Pesa and land in the group's ledger automatically. Payouts go out the same way, behind an approval. Every member can open the app and see their own history and the group's position without asking anyone - which turns a whole category of arguments into a lookup.

Each group is a separate tenant. Isolation is enforced in the database rather than in the app, so a member of one chama cannot see another chama's figures under any circumstances.

2. The four roles

Everyone signs in at the same address. Your role decides what appears once you are in.

- Admin - creates the group, invites and removes members, assigns roles, manages the subscription.
- Chairperson - approves payouts and loan disbursements, and sees the full group position.
- Treasurer - records and reconciles money, follows up unmatched or missing contributions.
- Member - contributes, and views their own statement plus the group totals.

The menu you see is built from the same permissions the database enforces. Hiding a button is a courtesy; the actual boundary sits underneath, so nothing can be reached by guessing a URL.

3. Signing in

1. Open the platform address and choose Sign in.
2. Enter one of the demo email and password pairs from the table at the front of this guide.
3. You land on the dashboard for that role. To try a different role, sign out and sign back in with another pair.

4. Admin - setting the group up

1. From the dashboard, open the group settings. Set the group name, the contribution amount and how often it is due.
 2. Open Members and invite people by email. Each invitee gets a link to set their own password.
 3. Assign a role as you invite - chairperson, treasurer or member. Roles can be changed later from the same screen.
 4. Review the subscription section to see the group's current plan and renewal date.
- Removing a member ends their access but leaves their contribution history in the ledger. Money records are never deleted.

- There is no way to edit a past contribution. Corrections are made by posting an adjusting entry, so the trail stays intact.

5. Member - making a contribution

1. Sign in as the member and open Contributions from the dashboard.
2. Choose Contribute. The amount is pre-filled from the group's schedule; change it if you are paying more or catching up.
3. Enter your Safaricom number as 07XXXXXXXX and confirm.
4. Approve the prompt on your handset with your M-Pesa PIN.
5. The contribution appears in your statement and in the group total as soon as Safaricom confirms - no screenshot to send to anyone.

Payments run against the M-Pesa sandbox, not live Safaricom rails. An STK Push prompt will not appear on a real handset and no money moves; the demo simulates the callback so you can follow the full flow end to end.

6. The ledger and statements

Everything is append-only. Contributions in and payouts out are both rows that are written once and never changed, and every balance you see is calculated from them rather than stored. That is what makes any figure on screen traceable back to the exact M-Pesa transaction behind it.

- My contributions - your own history, with dates, amounts and receipt numbers.
- Group position - total contributed, total paid out, and what the group is currently holding.
- Per-member summary - who is up to date and who is behind, visible to the whole group.

7. Chairperson - payouts and loans

Money leaving the group is a deliberately slower path than money coming in. Sending funds out is the one action that cannot be undone, so it is never a single click.

1. Open Payouts to see requests waiting on you, each with the requesting member, the amount and the reason.
2. Check the request against the group's position, shown alongside.
3. Approve or decline. An approval is recorded against your name and the time.
4. On approval the transfer is queued and shows as pending until Safaricom confirms it, at which point it is written into the ledger.

Payout requests carry an idempotency key, so a double-click or a retried request can never disburse the same money twice.

8. Subscription billing

Each group pays for the platform on its own plan. M-Pesa has no equivalent of a stored card that can be charged silently, so recurring billing means prompting a human on a schedule - which the platform is built around rather than against.

- The admin sees the plan, the renewal date and the payment history.
- A reminder goes out before renewal, and the renewal itself is an STK prompt the admin approves.
- A missed renewal moves the group into a grace period rather than cutting access off immediately.

9. If something goes wrong

- No M-Pesa prompt - confirm the number is a Safaricom line in 07XXXXXXX form, then try again. Only one prompt can be outstanding at a time.
- A contribution is missing - check the Unmatched queue. Payments that could not be tied to a member land there for the treasurer rather than being dropped.
- A menu item you expected is not there - you are signed in under a role that does not have it. Sign out and back in as admin or chairperson.
- A payout is stuck on pending - it is waiting on Safaricom's confirmation. It will settle or fail on its own; it will not silently vanish.
- You cannot sign in - passwords on the demo accounts are rotated periodically. Get in touch for the current set.